

A HAND FOR HAMMER & SICKLE
Congress leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury with CPI(M)'s Mohammed Salim at a rally in Baharampur, Apr. 18

LONE WARRIOR OF THE CONGRESS

THE VOLUBLE ADHIR RANJAN CHOWDHURY FIGHTS WITH HIS BACK TO THE WALL IN HIS BASTION OF BAHARAMPUR

BY ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR *in Baharampur*

CPI(M) state secretary Mohammed Salim, the alliance candidate from the Murshidabad seat.

Every monsoon, followers of the 'Robin Hood of Baharampur' amass rations, tarpaulin and other relief material, truckloads of which are sent to flood-hit areas. However, a lot has changed for Borda (elder brother) since 2009, when he got over 56 per cent of the polled votes. That year, he was the Congress-TMC alliance candidate. In 2024, the outgoing Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha is in a tough three-way contest with the TMC and the BJP. In Murshidabad, other than Salim, the Congress-Left alliance has fielded Chowdhury from Baharampur and Mortaza Hossain from Jangipur.

Chowdhury himself oozes confidence. "We will win all three seats in Murshidabad," he says. But that's the classic brave face statement. After their alliance ended in 2012, the TMC focused on weakening Chowdhury and managed to lure away some of his closest aides. The ground mirrored that shift: in 2021, TMC wrested six of the seven assembly seats in Baharampur; one went to the BJP.

This time around, the TMC has nominated former cricketer Yusuf Pathan from Baharampur. The party hopes the celebrity outsider will be able to consolidate Muslim votes in its favour. Baharampur has a Muslim population of about 59 per cent and their loyalty has been shifting TMCward from the Congress. In 2019, the four assembly segments wrested by TMC candidate Apurba Sarkar in terms of vote share have a Muslim population of 55 per cent to over 70 per cent. "Adhir was ahead of David (Sarkar) in three seats—Burwan, Kandi and Baharampur. Of these, the maximum lead of 89,061 votes came from Baharampur city, which locked his win. This time, it looks a little difficult," says poll analyst Biswajit Bhattacharya.

The BJP, too, made significant inroads in the Hindu-majority Baharampur city itself. In 2021, the assembly seat went to its man Subrata Maitra. In 2024, the BJP's candidate in Baharampur is Nirmal Kumar Saha, a surgeon with an RSS background. "Whoever wins Baharampur...it will be a close call," says Saha.

Chowdhury is also battling an undercurrent of anti-incumbency. Unemployment and outmigration are the bane of Murshidabad and many point fingers at the five-term MP. This is reflected in a decline in Chowdhury's vote share since 2009. Rivals now make bold to show their dissent openly. When Chowdhury went to the Baharampur Medical College on April 17 to meet victims of the communal clash in Shaktipur during a Ramnavami procession, he was denied entry by BJP supporters. Three days later, TMC supporters stopped his convoy.

"If the TMC plays up the Shaktipur incident, it might consolidate Muslim votes in its favour," says Bhattacharya. On April 23, the Calcutta High Court, while hearing a plea for a central probe into the incident, urged the Election Commission to postpone polls in Baharampur.

Chowdhury has a few advantages. In the 2023 panchayat polls, the Left-Congress alliance secured around 36 per cent votes in Baharampur—a realignment since 2021. Secondly, Pathan's inability to speak Bengali is keeping him from connecting with voters. Lastly, Chowdhury enjoys a core vote of 20-25 per cent. "Hindus and Muslims will vote for Borda...in Lok Sabha polls he is their choice," says Manoj Chakraborty, a former Congress leader. To be sure, Chowdhury needs all this to get him over the line. ■